

READING THE URBAN COMMONS



Banganga Mahaarti (Source: [BANGANGAMAHARTI](#).Instagram)

The Paradox of Governance: State vs Community in the Case of Banganga

Author : Omkar Dawale



Dig.1: Banganga Site (Source: Author)

Urban commons are shared resources within cities, water bodies, open spaces, and cultural sites that communities rely on for both material and symbolic life. These commons are not merely physical assets but hold deep **cultural, social, and ecological meaning**. Banganga Tank in Mumbai is one such urban commons. It is both a **sacred water body** central to Hindu rituals and a **living resource** that once supported fishing, dhobi (washermen), and other **community-based livelihoods**.

In recent decades, Banganga has **faced increasing interventions** by multiple state and heritage bodies the BMC (Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation), ASI (Archaeological Survey of India), MTDC (Maharashtra Tourism Development Corporation) each imposing regulations that have reshaped its use. While sacred rituals continue, the **living commons have been eroded**: dhobi activity and fishing was **prohibited under ASI's heritage site regulations**.

This essay examines Banganga through the framework of **Elinor Ostrom's** theory of **governing the commons**. It argues that if the local **Gaud Saraswat Brahmin (GSB) Trust**, which historically managed the tank, had retained authority over governance, both sacred and living commons could have survived together. The story of Banganga demonstrates the tension between **community self-organization** and **state intervention**.

Elinor Ostrom (1990) argued that communities can successfully manage shared resources through **self-organization**, without depending entirely on external control. She emphasized that

collective action, local knowledge, and trust play a central role in sustaining commons. Her framework **highlights flexible design principles** such as clear boundaries, locally adapted rules, participatory decision-making, monitoring, sanctions, and conflict resolution. Importantly, she stressed that local institutions should retain autonomy, with external agencies supporting rather than overriding them. Applied to urban settings, Ostrom's perspective shows that the survival of commons depends on governance arrangements that **balance cultural practices, ecology, and livelihoods**.

Research Question

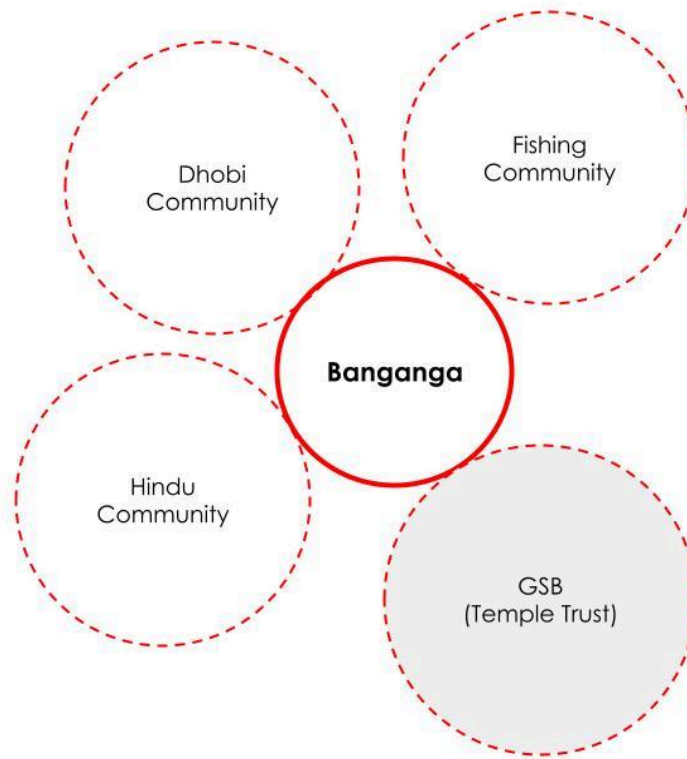
How does external governance reduce the livability of urban commons and restrict community based practices?

Methodology

This essay uses a **qualitative approach based on secondary sources**, heritage reports, and historical accounts of Banganga's management. It analyzes the site as a layered commons shaped by culture, institutions, and power, highlighting how community governance functioned and how external interventions disrupted it.

Banganga Tank, part of the **Walkeshwar temple complex** in Mumbai, has for centuries been maintained by the **GSB Trust**. For local communities, it was never just a sacred tank; it was a **living & sacred urban commons**. Ritual bathing, religious festivals, fishing, and laundry all coexisted, sustained by community-led management.

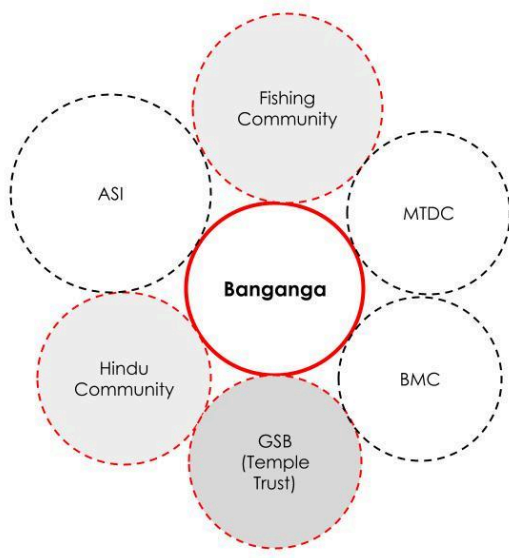
The GSB Trust historically balanced these uses. Fishing was allowed, regulated by community consensus. Dhobi activity, though utilitarian, eventually led to pollution, a challenge many commons faces. The Trust was capable of evolving rules: pollution could be managed with local negotiation. Importantly, fishing, an ancient livelihood tied to local community survival, was not considered in conflict with sacred use. **The myth that Hindu beliefs forbade fishing in the tank is a false narrative that emerged later**, obscuring the fact that the **Trust supported these activities**.



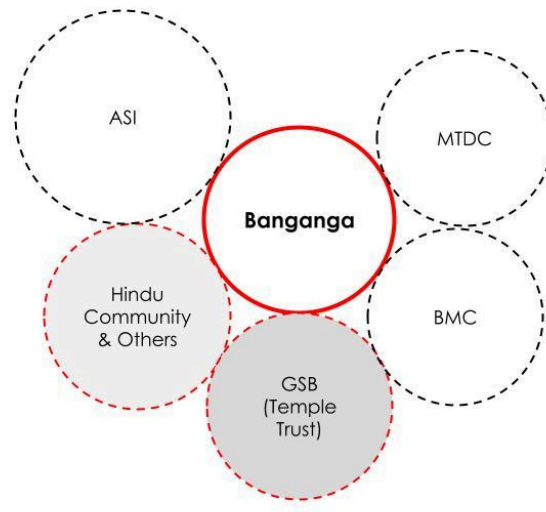
Dig.02: Banganga & Community *(Source: Author)*

The shift began when external bodies entered into the governance of the tank. The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) declared it a protected heritage site and imposed blanket restrictions, including a ban on fishing. The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) took charge of maintenance but did so with little regard for community practices. Meanwhile, the Maharashtra Tourism Development Corporation (MTDC) promoted the site primarily as a **cultural heritage destination, emphasizing its sacred image over its everyday living functions.**

These overlapping interventions reduced the GSB Trust's autonomy. As a result, Banganga today remains a **sacred commons for rituals, but has lost much of its living commons character.** Dhobi activity, though environmentally damaging, could have been phased out with community based alternatives. Fishing, however, was banned unnecessarily under heritage regulations, erasing a vital livelihood and weakening the plural identity of the tank.



Dig.03: (Source: Author)



Dig.04: (Source: Author)

Using Ostrom's lens, Banganga illustrates how **external interventions can destabilize an already well-functioning commons institution**. The GSB Trust had long embodied several of Ostrom's design principles. The tank had clear spatial and cultural boundaries, while community rules regulated activities such as fishing and washing through trust-led consensus. Misuse was managed within community norms, supported by local monitoring and enforcement, and conflicts were resolved through negotiation rather than imposed authority. Together, these practices **sustained both the sacred and living functions** of the tank until external bodies disrupted the balance.

The entry of ASI, BMC, and MTDC disrupted this system. Instead of strengthening local governance, they imposed top-down restrictions that privileged **heritage preservation over livelihoods**. While sacred rituals remain protected, living practices have been excluded. In effect, **the commons have been fragmented: sacred preserved, living erased**.

Ostrom's theory highlights that such fragmentation undermines sustainability. A true urban commons is one that integrates multiple uses and community voices. By sidelining the GSB Trust, state agencies transformed Banganga into a **partial commons alive in ritual but diminished in everyday life**.

The story of Banganga reveals the commodification & fragility of urban commons when multiple authorities intervene without coordination or respect for community institutions. The GSB Trust

demonstrated **the capacity for self-governance**, balancing sacred and living needs. External regulation disrupted this, leading to bans that erased everyday livelihoods.

Ostrom's work explains that common governance thrives when **local institutions are empowered**, not undermined. Banganga's case is a reminder that **heritage preservation must coexist with community practices**, not replace them.

Banganga illustrates a larger truth about urban commons: they are never only physical or only symbolic. They are **hybrid spaces where sacred, cultural, and material life intersect**. Policies that privilege one dimension over another sacred over living, heritage over livelihood inevitably distort the commons.

I agree with Ostrom's central claim: **communities can self-organize and govern commons effectively. The GSB Trust is evidence of this capacity. However, I also recognize that not all community practices are sustainable dhobi activity causing pollution required intervention.** Here, external support could have been constructive if it worked with the Trust rather than overriding it.

References:

Ostrom, E. (1990). *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action*. Cambridge University Press.:
<https://www.cambridge.org/core/books/governing-the-commons/9C3BAE9F15E8E3C59E3E0B1E2C06D8A9>

Foster, S., & Iaione, C. (2016). *The City as a Commons*. *Yale Law & Policy Review*, 34(2).:
<https://digitalcommons.law.yale.edu/ylpr/vol34/iss2/2/>

Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH). *Reports on Mumbai heritage*.:
<https://www.intach.org/mumbai-chapter.php>

Archaeological Survey of India (ASI). *Heritage site listings*.
<https://www.maharashtratourism.gov.in/>

Maharashtra Tourism Development Corporation (MTDC). *Information on heritage tourism in Mumbai*.
<https://www.maharashtratourism.gov.in/>

<https://mumbaitourism.travel/banganga-tank-mumbai>